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Laurence Juber

English guitarist Laurence Juber was born on November 12, 1952 and was playing gigs at age 13. He fulfilled his ambition of becoming a studio musician by becoming a first-call guitarist in London and L.A. Acoustic Guitar *magazine has named him one of the top fingerstyle guitarists of all time. Although he missed playing with John, he did perform with Paul, George and Ringo.*

Laurence was interviewed in Glasgow, Scotland on July 27, 2016, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive, and I'm privileged to have Laurence Juber with me today. Congratulations on your career.

LJ: Well thank you.

MR: I'm envious of it, mostly because I really admire people who wear different hats, who do this for a while then find they can do that for a while.

LJ: You know I'm blessed with having had a career as a musician. And I really, from the very beginning my goal was to be versatile. Because around age 13 I learned about being a studio musician and how that was, if you could get into that world, that would be a reliable source of income.

MR: Can I ask you how you learned about —

LJ: I played — there was a local band leader, a trumpet player, who kind of mentored me. He wasn't really a trained musician but he was one of those local kind of semi-professional guys. And he had a quite successful little combo that played weddings and corporate events and stuff. And I found myself on the bandstand at 13 years old with musicians that were professional level players. In fact the drummer, Martin Drew, was a huge Oscar Peterson fan. And eventually he became Oscar Peterson's drummer in the U.K. And I remember the first gig the bass player leaned over and he said, "Lad, if you don't know the chords just play the bridge of 'I've Got Rhythm'." You know, the circle of fifths.

MR: The circle will get you around.

LJ: And very useful advice. And of course I didn't know the chords. But that was my ear training, it was on the bandstand.

MR: What kind of songs would you have been playing?

LJ: Oh that was, you know, I mean "Strangers in the Night," you know, "Spanish Eyes." But standards. The Great American Songbook. Because this would have been like 1965. Round about there. So what I was listening to was not that at all. I was listening to The Beatles, The Stones, The Animals. And then through The Stones I discovered Muddy Waters and Howlin' Wolf and the roots.

MR: I love watching, playing with older fellas, you not only learn the music you watch how they operate with the audience, and taking requests and the whole thing about playing a gig.

LJ: Yeah. I understood the professional context of it, that this was a job. It wasn't just get out there and show how fast you can play or whatever. Because always for me it was about the act of making music. And I really didn't have a lot of repertoire. I didn't study in the way of kind of building a repertoire for myself. It was like go and play and figure out what was going on in the moment. I was quite improvisational at that point. But I was also studying music. I started playing classical guitar in high school. That was something that really got me engaged. Music appreciation was extremely useful to me, because I learned how to listen to music. And I discovered Bach for example from — there was a record called "The Lovers Concerto" by The Toys, which was one of the Anna Magdalena waltzes [hums]. And it was like whoa, what's this? And that led me into Bach and then I got hold of the record of Julian Bream playing the Bach lute suites on classical guitar. But the first record that really drew me in was this trumpet player, Phil, gave me a record by the Candoli brothers.

MR: Conte and Pete.

LJ: Yeah. Who were the L.A. studio players who were representing the west coast, the L.A. jazz scene. I guess that record would have been made early 60s. Howard Roberts on guitar. And I'd slow the record down and try and figure out the licks. And then I discovered Django Reinhardt. But I was also doing the same thing with Eric Clapton with John Mayall's Blues Breakers records and Jimi Hendrix. And I had a little band with some friends of mine and we'd get together once a week and whatever the new Who single or the Stones single or whatever it was, we would learn it.

MR: And you learned it by playing the record, right?

LJ: Yeah. We'd just learn it off the record. I mean you didn't go out and buy the sheet music. Because the sheet music was always some kind of semi-accurate piano arrangement with like ukulele chords.

MR: And in the wrong key probably.

LJ: Oh yeah, typically.

MR: Do you listen, do you recall listening for the bass notes?

LJ: Oh totally. I listened to all the parts. We had Radio Luxembourg, was, you know, broadcast from the continent, so it wasn't restricted to the same playlists that the BBC had, which was, at that time, we didn't have Radio One, Radio Two until somewhat later. 1963, '64 it was The Light Program or The Home Service or whatever. So you got a very eclectic mix there anyway. But Radio Luxembourg was all-American top 40. So that's where I heard all those records. I heard Motown Records for the first time. And I'd be

listening to what the rhythm section was doing, and how the bass and the kick drum work together, as were Lennon McCartney and Ringo and Harrison, as far as they were listening to that stuff and then creating a British version of it. In fact the first time a Motown song was ever played on British radio was by The Beatles in 1962. I forget which song it was. But it was a live broadcast and they played a Motown song. Because you didn't hear that, and then you did. Then all of a sudden you started to hear that stuff. And we got Tamla Motown, because they had Tamla and the Motown. It was a joint label in England. But I was listening to a lot of American R&B and soul music, and reggae too. And I was just fascinated, for example, with some of these corporate gigs that I would do with this band, they would have a steel drum band and I was just fascinated by the rhythmic articulation of that. And so when I was listening to records I was listening not only to the parts but also to the groove. And I didn't really understand, to begin with I didn't understand it until once I got into studio work and I realized that I was playing one of those roles, I was coming up with licks or grooves, or little inner-moving parts. And it started to make sense as I got deeper into music theory, how it all fit together and the puzzle of it.

MR: Did you get a reputation in the studio for a certain style?

LJ: I was a versatile guy. I mean if they needed a banjo I'd go and borrow a banjo for the session. But because I understood the nature of the versatility. Now as a teenager I was playing with rock bands as well as doing the money stuff. And I mean making five pounds for a gig was a lot better than babysitting or washing my neighbor's car, although if I washed my neighbor's car I got tickets for Tottenham Hotspur's games, which was the local soccer team. So it was worth it. But I was doing a lot of stuff. I mean as soon as I was able to I started going to National Youth Jazz Orchestra camps and hooked up with an alto sax player and he and I would go — I was probably about 18 at the time. He and I would go and play gigs where we had no repertoire, we would just improvise for a whole gig, just like riffing and grooving. Any musical experience was happy for me. So I was studying classical guitar. I took that up to Grade 8, because I needed it in order to study music. I took Grade 5 classical guitar so I could do A level music. I took Grade 8 so I would be able to go to college. And by the time I left high school I knew I wanted to be a studio musician. I got accepted at Leeds College of Music in the North of England, which was the closest thing we had to the Berklee School of Music, as far as you could actually study jazz and you could study all that stuff there, versus going to one of the conservatories for example. But when I got better exam grades than I expected, in fact my music teachers were shocked that I got an A in music. Because I was kind of on the hooligan side as far as I wasn't legit. I wasn't part of the classical canon. I didn't play an orchestral instrument. I was a lousy piano player. And guitar was kind of the orphan

stepchild of that whole world. And still to this day it's somewhat that way. So when I got better grades than I expected I said wait a minute, why am I going to leave London? I grew up in London and I'd been paying my dues as a teenager and getting demo sessions and playing with all these cats, why do I want to leave all that? So I canceled my application to Leeds, took a gap year — I was a pioneer of the gap year. I mean this was like 1971. And I applied to Goldsmith's College, London University, which was the only place in London that you could actually study musicology and music theory and all of that within a degree structure that didn't require being basically a church organist that could improvise fugues in three parts with hands and feet and do all that stuff. Because there was still that kind of church music thrust in music education. And Stanley Glasser, who was the professor at Goldsmith's, I went in for my interview and we spent the whole time talking about Barney Kessel and Joe Pass, and American jazz guitar players. Because he understood the nature of my world. And he was my champion at Goldsmith's. I mean for ear training for example. I was not that great at transcribing when it would be like Schoenberg's F# minor string quartet, stuff like that.

MR: And sight singing?

LJ: Sight singing I was okay. Because I could sight read. I learned to sight read on a rainy afternoon when I was 11 years old. I had a book called *Play in the Day*. Burt Weedon's *Play in the Day*. I mean you talk to anybody from that generation, they all learned out of *Play in the Day*. And in the back of the book was "When the Saints Go Marching in" and it's in C and okay, that's a C, that's a C, I get it. It wasn't rocket science.

MR: Can I ask what your parents thought about your path?

LJ: I mean they were fine with me playing the guitar, from their point of view, as long as I had something to fall back on. And I was never academic enough to go for medicine, which would have been kind of the brass ring, to be a doctor. So I said well maybe a pharmacist. But the thing is both of my parents left school in their mid-teens. I mean my dad at 14 and my mom at 15. Because this was London during the blitz. You know, they came from the East end of London which was kind of like the Lower East Side in New York, I mean it wasn't a wealthy area. And there were bombs dropping all the time and it was like their educations were really disrupted. And my dad really wanted to be a tailor. And he also loved saxophone. What he wanted me to do was play the tenor sax. And for my birthday when I was like eight, nine and ten, I would get a recorder, which was like heading in that direction. And it was like okay this is kind of fun but it's not what those guys are playing, it's not what The Shadows are playing on television with a red Stratocaster and the fancy foot moves and all that stuff.

MR: Did they like that music?

LJ: It was kind of suspicious until November of 1963 when Beatlemania crested in England and The Beatles performed on the Royal Command Performance. That was the show where John Lennon made the wise crack about clap along, and those of you rattle your jewelry, the royalty. That kind of legitimized the guitar. My 11th birthday was a week later and I got a guitar. It was not a great guitar but it was the best guitar in the world.

MR: Was it acoustic?

LJ: It was an acoustic. It was a little Russian or Czech-made acoustic. Because that was where you got your low-cost guitars from, was what is now the Czech Republic. It was then Czechoslovakia. Because they had a centuries old tradition of guitar making in those areas. And the action was like this. But it had a floating fingerboard, which that goes back to the old Viennese school of guitars in the early 19th century where they had like a key that you could adjust the fingerboard. I didn't know that. For me it was just like there was a bulb and if you stuffed cardboard underneath it, it raised the fingerboard enough that it actually was playable. And it wasn't a real ebony fingerboard, it was kind of painted black so all the black stuff would come off on your fingers. But it was my instrument and I fell in love with it. And I guess I never let go, and I still love it. And after I'd had it a week or so my dad took me to see a friend of his who was an amateur guitar player, who showed me how to play an F major 7 chord which was the most gorgeous thing I'd ever heard. And then he showed me how to play a C 9 chord, which was equally gorgeous. And I think that I internalized that sonority, that the tone of an acoustic guitar really became something very precious to me, which is I think what ultimately led me back to being a specialist in acoustic.

MR: Because you took classical, guitar has always mystified me a little bit. I'm a piano player and a saxophone player. But because you played classical and if you played an F major 7 and you're looking at your hand, you know what the notes are.

LJ: Of course.

MR: But not all guitar players do I think.

LJ: True. Yeah I mean I've done concerts with guitar players who were purely primitive in their conception of the instrument but can do remarkable things. You don't have to have the musical understanding. But what's interesting about the guitar, and kind of unique I mean in the context of it being affordable, portable, versatile, and capable of making a complete musical statement because it incorporates rhythm, harmony, counterpoint, melody, all within its accessible performance, that what's curious about the guitar is because the notes are not in fixed positions. You know you can change the tuning for example and the notes move. That if you understand music and you play guitar, then the meta information, the pure musical information, which never changes, I mean a C is always a C but it moves into different positions, depending on the context. Even a

standard tuning you could play a middle C in four, five different positions. The mental process there is different. Because on a piano a note is always a note. It doesn't shift. And mostly on an orchestral instrument or a band instrument the notes are mostly in the same place. I mean you can do crazy fingerings and overblow notes and stuff on the sax, which is really cool, but on the guitar if you combine the musical education and the guitarology of it, the guitaristics of it, that's where you get into some really interesting and unique musical areas. And that's something that just completely engages me.

MR: Well said. Well you went from, I was looking at your "has played with" — everyone from Alan Parsons to Rosemary Clooney.

LJ: Yeah. And that was all in the space of a couple of years then, you know, back in the 70s. I mean it goes way beyond that. I mean three out of the four Beatles. I played with at least two Muppets, actually more than two Muppets. I played banjo for some of Kermit's stuff —

MR: I'm not sure which is better, I mean they're both up there.

LJ: Well actually doing a session with the Great Gonzo was — it was Paul Williams, Willie Nelson, and the Great Gonzo all at once. I was a giant because Paul's not a tall guy, and Willie's not a tall guy, and the Great Gonzo is about that big. And you forget it's a puppet. You know the guy that's operating it just fades into the background and you're interacting with this, what feels like a real character, which is what's so great. Because when a character is that real, even if it's blue.

MR: Yeah, and then after you're done it feels weird because a person comes out —

LJ: Yeah. It's a kind of reality check. But I mean this really goes along with the ambition to be a studio musician was just it doesn't matter who you're playing with it's making music. I mean it looks good on the resume to have — that record with Rosemary Clooney was really cool. And I was 24, 25 at the time. It was mid-70s in London and she was making a comeback and she was on tour with Bing Crosby. It was not long before he died. And it was just a very cool experience, you know, playing with somebody of that kind of caliber. The Alan Parsons project I had no idea that I played on the record until I read it in *Musician Magazine* 25 years later. It was a session at Abbey Road on a Tuesday night and there was a string orchestra, a harpsichord player, some mandolins and acoustic guitar. And it didn't say on the music what it was. And at Abbey Road there's this long staircase that goes all the way up to the control room. You never went up there. If you were a studio player you didn't go up there unless you were invited. The first time I ever went up there was actually I was doing a record session there in April of '78 and there was a phone call for me, this was before cell phones. And it was like really unusual. And I went up to take this phone call. And I went, "oh, that's the control room." And it turned out that it was McCartney's office asking if I would go and audition.

MR: And they called you at Apple.

LJ: No, at Abbey Road. Because they tracked me down. But it's always been this kind of, oh here's some music, come up with a cool guitar sound, and who's the artist again? And it just has, over the years, because not just in London but in Los Angeles too. Because when I got to L.A. I got very involved in the studio scene. And not so much on the record side, more on the T.V. and movie side. So I'm walking into a session and there's Ernie Watts playing sax in the section, or these great drummers that I've worked with — Jim Keltner and John Robinson and Vinnie Colaiuta.

MR: You became like the second "wrecking crew?"

LJ: Well it was a different world. I mean the wrecking crew really the span of that was '59 through '75. That was when the record business was really, really cooking. But the business just continued. And walking into a Disney session — I played on "Pocahontas" and "Colors of the Wind" and there's this huge orchestra and there's eight double basses and three harps and a guitar.

MR: Don't you at least have to know what instrument to bring?

LJ: You just bring them all. Yeah. I mean the cartage companies do great. I mean if there's cartage in the budget, and I do a lot of sessions now. I mean mostly if I do a session I just walk in with a couple of acoustic guitars. Because I tend to get booked on that one. But I mean there would be sessions where I'd have multiple amplifiers, maybe two dozen guitars — because you have to have all the different instruments. You know if they call for an electric 12-string or acoustic 12-string, banjo, mandolin, Renaissance lute.

MR: Who are some of the producers that you've worked with?

LJ: Well in L.A. I did a lot of work, and still do, with a producer named Michael Lloyd who's very, very pop. He's a very pop producer. He did like teen stars in the 70s — Shaun Cassidy and Leif Garrett and people like that. But we did a lot of stuff, especially in the 80s. Belinda Carlisle's first album. There is a song called "Mad About You" which was a big hit round about '87, '88. And you know I'd first heard it on the radio. I never really heard the whole song because when we cut the track it was just me and the drummer. As a session player, very often, you know, it's a utility gig. And for that I was just playing eighth notes on a Fender Stratocaster and with the drummer, and we had a chord chart and, you know, laid down a track, and then I hear it on the radio and, oh that's what that was all about. And then we did, there was a low budget movie that we were doing songs for that ended up being called "Dirty Dancing." And that's the biggest selling album I ever played on. I mean "Time of my Life" and "She's Like the Wind" were big hits. That album sold over 40 million last time I looked.

MR: Do you get checks in the mail?

LJ: Mostly it's direct deposit these days. But you know what's really been an amazing thing is when I first started doing sessions in London, it was — I forget what it was — it was like maybe 17 pounds or something for a 3 hour session. And then I joined Wings and it's a whole different experience. And what got me into Wings was my versatility also. I mean that's always been kind of a calling card for me is the fact that I can play multiple styles, which that's the way that Paul operates as an artist, Paul McCartney operates, is that stylistically it was all over the map. We did — one song we did, "Baby's Request" was a demo for the Mills Brothers. And it starts off with me doing my best kind of Barney Kessel licks. And then we'd do kind of this almost punk rock kind of stuff. And then big kind of McCartney ballads. And it was really a very broad stylistic range. Because you're not dealing with an artist that works in a specific genre. You're working with an artist who creates a genre. Really. He is the genre.

MR: What was the audition like?

LJ: I borrowed some Wings LPs from my brother. And it turned out that what we played was some Chuck Berry tunes and some reggae grooves and they offered me the gig. But when I got to L.A. it was a very different world, because the union, the AF of M was much more involved than the English musicians' union. So all of a sudden I find myself — you know I did some jingle sessions in New York for Lincoln Mercury and then all of a sudden I'm getting all these checks. Whereas in England I'd go to an 8 AM jingle and you'd get paid for the session and that's the end of it. I'm starting to get checks from Local 802 in New York, and then when I moved to L.A., Local 47, and I'm getting into doing movie sessions. And I played on — there was one piece of original music on The Big Chill where one of the characters has a T.V. show and we recorded a theme for that T.V. show. And the next July I get a check from the secondary payments fund for many thousands of dollars, because there were only a small group of musicians who played on the score. And that's when I discovered that. And then when I started getting into composing and I did the Brady Bunch Christmas movie, "A Very Brady Christmas" and all of a sudden I get this package in the mail and I qualified for health insurance. So it was a different — it was a more involved business model. And now, since Sound Exchange, I get performance royalties for my airplay on Pandora or Sirius, for my own stuff, but also the secondary markets fund from SAG AFTRA now have a performance fund, PPL which is the U.K. one which picks up the neighboring rights. That's where I see more money from the Wings records that I played on for example. And it was only later that I started learning about ASCAP and BMI and being able to pick up kind of the writer side of it. So that kind of expanded my vision of where the revenue streams were. But to begin with it was just write out a little invoice, send it to the contractor or "fixer" as we call them in England. A man named David Katz was the one who got me started.

He'd seen me on television with the National Youth Jazz Orchestra and called me up the next day and said — he called everybody darling. He said, "Darling, I've got some sessions for you." And he gave me the dates. I said, "David, I hate to say this, but those are my final exams for my bachelor of music degree." And I just couldn't — you know I'd been studying for three years, I wasn't going to skip the finals. And I didn't think I'd hear from him again, but as it turned out he called a couple of weeks later. And he became my kind of studio mentor. And eventually he got me into the session for "The Spy Who Loved Me" and I got to play the James Bond theme, which, how cool is that?

MR: Well this may be a silly questions, but did your ears and hearing survive the Wings experience?

LJ: Yeah. We weren't that loud on stage. I think that playing with headphones though, for years, has done more damage to my hearing. Yeah we had a good sound system. Paul didn't like being that loud on stage. But Wings was more of a pop group than the kind of full-on rock bands with the jet engine decibels.

MR: Was he a good boss?

LJ: Oh yeah. Yeah. It was a great education. I got my master's degree from McCartney University. He was a good boss. I mean he's still — we went to Japan and he got busted on the way in. He wasn't that good a boss, in that respect. But as a creative boss, in terms of being in a creative situation, the first time I recorded a guitar solo with him we were doing a song called "To You." And I was playing in the studio and Paul was in the control room with an Eventide harmonizer changing the pitch of every note I was playing. And it was so cool. Because we were in that musical moment where I was improvising, he was improvising, but in a techno way. Very clever. And then the next solo I did was kind of a rockabilly thing, where I'm just sitting closer than you and I are sitting, right here, and I'm playing just eye to eye, you know. And he brought stuff out of me. I mean as a producer that's the great thing. I mean I've worked with some really fine producers. George Martin was one of the first producers I worked with, the Beatles producer. And I played on an album for Cleo Laine and John Dankworth. And George Martin was producing it and just his whole manner of putting you at ease. And I was pretty green at that point. We were doing something in B major and it was like I was toughing it out without a capo. Now I would never hesitate to put a capo on. But this was more of a jazz context and I really figured I can do this. Of course it took a little patience there. But now actually I would not hesitate to play without a capo in B major if I was doing something really creative, because B major you have, and G sharp minor for example, you have three open strings in G sharp minor. You have E, a B and an F double sharp. And using open strings, in terms of the texture and the sonority, is something that

over the years I really learned the value of. But there's nothing like playing it in A and putting the capo on the second fret.

MR: Do you sort of take it in stride, or are there time that you reflect on the fact that, well I've played with most of the Beatles and I've played under George Martin and these are people I listened to when I was 15. What a life?

LJ: Oh I mean it's an amazing life. But I think that I'm still learning. And I still look forward to the times when I get to work with somebody of stature, musical stature. Or not necessarily stature but of musical depth. And just how much more there is to learn. I love being able to go into a concert with an orchestra or a session with an orchestra. Because I get home and I pick up my acoustic guitar and I've got bassoons and I've got cellos and I've got inner parts all — guitar orchestration is part of what I do. And so to be able to reflect on that, the musical substance of all that. And part of what I do now is to pay it forward. I mean I do a lot of pro bono high schools, middle schools, elementary schools, where I'll just go and do an assembly and play for the kids and explain what a guitar is and what you can do with it. And each age group has its own particular kind of resonances. "Mister, did you meet Kermit?" kind of thing. Whereas videogame music that I've written appeals to the high school. So it's just — I think what I really appreciate is the ability to have a life in music and to be able to be creative — whether that's as an artist, or — as a solo guitarist my main focus — or as a composer, as an arranger, producer, all the different nuances, working in musical theater, working theater improvisational theater too. I mean I just did an album of improvisations with William Goldstein who is a film composer, who practices what he calls "instant composition." You give him three notes and he'll spin out a whole composition out of it. Well he and I improvised an album which just came out a few months ago. And the joy of listening back to something and knowing that you achieved something in that musical moment where you weren't trying to force the issue but just allowing creativity to happen, and how much interesting and engaging music can come out of that. You know it's a lost skill in the young jazz-rock-folk kind of world. I mean when you get into the classical world improvisation has kind of — they've forgotten that that was really the root of it.

MR: Do you have kids?

LJ: Yes I do. I have two daughters and I have two grandchildren too.

MR: Yeah. Just like us.

LJ: But my youngest — how old are your grandkids?

MR: Three and one.

LJ: Just like us.

MR: Do your kids, this sounds silly, but do they know of your accomplishments?

LJ: Oh yeah. Both of my daughters are very hip. My youngest daughter is a successful songwriter. And she found her own path with it, when she was a teenager and beyond, we supported her, encouraged her. She knows the business. She knows how it works. And she's been having hit records, not only as a writer but also as a singer. Last year she had a platinum record in Germany, Australia, Sweden, South Africa, as a singer and as a writer. So yeah, they're aware of all of this. It constantly surprises me how enduring the Beatles legacy is and how deep that goes. The Beatleology, just the musicology of the Beatles has become so advanced in terms of the historical aspect of it, the social aspect of it. Even the instruments and the recording process and everything, and how unique that was and how enduring.

MR: Well I couldn't agree more. And we were in Liverpool before this and did the thing.

LJ: Yeah I'll be there next month.

MR: And we were in the Beatles shop and there was this scholarly looking book and I opened it up and it was about the Beatles songwriting and I landed on this sentence and it was talking about the use of the Locrian scale. And I thought wow.

LJ: That goes back to — I mean that goes back to Wilfred Mellers, and in the mid-60s he wrote a book called *Twilight of the Gods* which was a very intense musicological analysis of Beatles songwriting.

MR: Do you agree with the concept of analyzing their work from a classical theoretical sense like that?

LJ: I don't consider analysis to be the province of classical. We associate music education with classical because we use the classical canon as the core of that repertoire. But because of being a guitar player, and the guitar is not considered truly part of the classical canon, other than the Segovia paradigm, the Spanish classical guitar which Segovia succeeded in bringing the gravitas and putting it in the concert hall. But what he represented in terms of the guitar was a pretty narrow focus. Even within his own paradigm it's a pretty narrow focus. But you go back to the early nineteenth century when there was guitarmania in Europe, in fact my presentation I call "Guitarmania to Beatlemania" because the guitar was extremely important in music-making. I mean Berlioz, Schubert, Diabelli, Musicalis, to name a few, Hummel, they're all guitar players. Schubert wrote many of his songs on guitar. The music that was published, there's an enormous amount of pieces that were published. The levels of virtuosity — Legnani, Italian guitar player, was the Paginini of the guitar, and did concerts with Paginini. In fact the story is that they had a concert piece that they had performed together, and toward the end they'd swap instruments. Because Paginini was a guitar player too. I think the only pieces that he wrote that didn't include a guitar were the 24 Caprice. And then Legnani wrote 36 Caprice, in every key, that are fiendishly difficult. But the virtuosi, not just

guitar virtuosi but virtuosi in general outside of that strict classical canon, they were not included. And the level of musicianship that — it is very tangible. That it wasn't just that they were developing technique. Aguado, who is pretty much the father of modern classical guitar technique, he was kind of the pedagogue, really the principal pedagogue. Fernando Sor, for example, was a very accomplished composer. He was a songwriter, he wrote a vocal method, he wrote a guitar method. He played guitar with really a technique more akin to lute technique than modern guitar technique. But his method starts with harmony. Now he is not considered classical in the sense of being part of the canon. But in that late Classical/early Romantic era, they were extremely accomplished. And where is the division between the C major chord that is classical or jazz or pop or rock? There is none. The meta information does not change. And who can improvise? Not the classical musicians, mostly, because they never learned. There are guitar players that go four years of conservatory training and can't string a chord sequence together. But those musicians were expected to. They were all expected to improvise, they have to read figured bass, all of that stuff. So I think that in a sense, the designation of classical theory really it just puts things too much in a box. So my experience is that music is music and it doesn't matter what the stylistic context is. Obviously one needs to study the classics. But I was having a conversation yesterday with somebody who had done some kind of event about who was the better composer, Handel or Bach. And I started thinking about that and realized that you know Handel was a commercial composer. Bach was a utility composer. He composed for his patrons and he composed for the church. But Handel wrote commercial music. And the opera composers of the nineteenth century were the commercial songwriters of that era, much in the same way as for example, I will take a Beatles song and arrange it. Well the early Romantic guitar players, the guitarmania era people and really between the French revolution and the 1848 revolution, that period really, the first half of the nineteenth century, they were accomplished in all those parameters that we associate with classical music. But it's only a footnote in the history books. So what my position is, fine. You don't want to call it classical? It's popular music. They arranged opera tunes. They wrote their own compositions. Johann Caspar Mertz for example, was the Schumann of the guitar. I mean his music is incredibly impressionistic in the stuff that he was writing in the 1830s and 1840. But always very guitaristic. Zani deFerranti was an Italian guitarist. Berlioz said, "he rocks you," literally that's what Berlioz said. So he was the first rock guitar player. And so they're not considered, I mean in the classical guitar world yes, it's a label. You can say these are classical guitar players. But in their era they weren't. And to my mind they do what I do. They toured, they were the first international touring musicians. A lot of guitar players toured internationally. They arranged pop songs. They wrote their own music. They did

method books, they published, they made their money, as much as they could, on publishing. Diabelli published an enormous amount of guitar music.

MR: Well you were, before we turned the camera on, you were saying you perform tomorrow night, and then the "real" gigs start. And I wondered what that means.

LJ: Oh only in terms of just the money gigs. I mean I'm here at this conference on my own recognizance. It's not like they hired me to come and perform. And I did a short artist-in-residence thing at Northeast Washington University. And Sheila, who is the current chairwoman said, "oh you should come to the conference, we'll get you a performance spot." And so I went through — my presentation that I'm doing, I had to put in an application like everybody else does. But it fit right into my own agenda. I got approached by the Los Angeles School District to help bridge the gap between the rock band guitar players, the little kids rock end spectrum, and then the classical end of the spectrum. Because there's this chasm. And I know from my own experience that it was hard to be taken seriously as a legit musician by being a guitar player, and by not being a conservatory classical guitar player. Because that at least had the gravitas to it. But playing on steel strings, I mean it just doesn't fit into that world. And yet you go back and you look at the instruments that were being played in the early nineteenth century — I play a guitar made by the C.F. Martin Company. C.F. Martin were established in 1833 in New York. But Mr. Martin worked in the factory of Stauffer in Vienna. Stauffer not only made guitars, he also made the arpeggioni that Schubert played. And Schubert played a Stauffer guitar. And a lot of the guitar players in that era played standing up. You know the guitars had strap buttons on them. They didn't play with the footstool. Giuliani, who was one of the greats, kind of almost the Moses of the classical guitar, played standing up. And the guitars, Stauffer's guitars, have a floating fingerboard and they have a long soundboard with a thick top. Those guitars sound almost like archtop guitars. They don't sound like the Spanish type classical guitar. You can play the music of that era on a steel string, a good steel string guitar, like my signature Martin, and the quick decay and the character of the sound is not like classical guitar as we experience it. Now that, over the last few years we have players like, in the Czech Republic, Pavel Steidl, who specializes in playing music of Legnani, Pagnini and music of that era, on authentic instruments. And it's a different experience. It's a different kind of sound. And that's something that has only recently been rediscovered. It just got lost.

MR: Well it's a good thing that you're pursuing that.

LJ: Well I'm trying to bridge the gap between that era and the modern era, and how — I look at it from the utility of it. And I call it becoming a practical guitar player. But if you understand music and you understand all the parameters, the harmonic, the melodic, the contrapuntal, the tonal, the sonority of it, the ability of the guitar to integrate into an

ensemble, and the professional parameters of gigging, of making a living doing it — but also, when I refer to the real work starting — I mean Monday night next week I have a solo concert. And it'll be a two hour concert. Whereas tomorrow night it's 45 minutes and it's like okay, the youth orchestra is on next. It's stacked programming, like a festival. But when I have a solo concert — you know I've written 150 pieces for guitar. I've arranged probably that many again. You know I have to choose my repertoire based not on the pedagogy of it, but on the entertainment value of it. Tuesday night I'm playing the Pizza Express Jazz Club in London, and my guest guitar player is Nicholas Fitch, who is the current guitar player with NYJO, with the National Youth Jazz Orchestra. So we're bridging the generations. And we're going to play Chick Corea's "Spain" and with two guitars it'll be a lot of fun. And we'll do some standards together, and then he'll do a few solo tunes and I'll do it myself. And the next night I have a rhythm section. I have two — a great English jazz drummer, Steven Keogh, and Arnie Somogyi the bass player. And we'll do some trio stuff. And then I fly back to the states and go to Nazareth, Pennsylvania, where Martin Guitars is based, and I'm headlining their Martinfest. So it's like I'm going from a kind of London jazz context to East Coast American guitar company that has been in business since 1833, has its roots in a Vienese guitarmaking tradition, which still, my guitar, as many acoustic guitars do, have a pin bridge. As opposed to the tie bridge on the classic nylon string, where they tie the string around the bridge. And the pin bridge is a pin that holds the string in place on the bridge. That goes back to Vienna. That goes back to Stauffer. That's not a modern invention. And what I go for when they build a guitar for me is to try to link back to that tradition, to bring it back to the roots of the six string guitar. Because that really started in the 1770s. Before that the Baroque guitar was basically like a giant ukulele.

MR: Well your career reminds me of Bucky Pizzarelli, who I've got to know fairly well. And what's next, what's tomorrow.

LJ: I have an album, a vinyl album of Bucky Pizzarelli with a group of other guitar players doing arrangements of Bix Beiderbecke's piano pieces, "In a Mist."

MR: Well just a couple more things before we wrap up. I wondered, do you recall the most difficult studio experience you ever had? Did they ever have to do a retake because of you?

LJ: Oh, well you have to acknowledge the fact that there are times when you just need a little more time to work something out. Sometimes it just gets purely scary. Warner Brothers for example, Warner Brothers soundstage. It's a huge soundstage, like the size of a football field. And in one corner there's an isolation booth. In another corner there's an isolation booth. And if you're in an isolation booth you cannot (which is typically where the guitar gets put) you can't hear the conductor. And if you don't have headphones on,

you're screwed. So it's like come back from a ten, sit down, they've already called the cue. Headphones are on, the clicks, eight free clicks, the baton is up, and you have no idea what we're playing. And it's like okay, stop tape. Nowadays it's much easier. In the old days they had to rack up film. In the old days when I started doing sessions at Paramount in the early 80s, they were running film. They would project film. It was very old school. It was the tail end of the old studio orchestra system. So I've had my embarrassing moments. But then sometimes you just nail it. And I've had experiences where you just — eight pages of altered tuning 12-string on a Western style score where it's just acoustic guitar and a string orchestra.

MR: Boy the person who arranged that must have known what the guitar was capable of.

LJ: Well that particular composer, Dan Foliart, who I've worked with for over 30 years, he did "Roseanne," "Home Improvement," a lot of shows. We did a show for 11 years called "Seventh Heaven" where the acoustic guitar was extremely prominent. Finger style acoustic guitar. And he was always write in different tunings. But he knows the instrument. But how do you notate that? You can't write tablature because the copyists wouldn't know what to do with it. So we worked out a system where he would write it in standard notation and I would play it as though it were in standard tuning. So if I saw an E at the top of the stave, I would play the open top string, even though that might have been tuned to a D or a C sharp. So I had to turn off that inner ear thing that goes along with sight reading. And he would use multiple tunings during the session. So I'd have like two, three, sometimes even four guitars. And that kind of thing — we thought we'd invented that. And then I discovered that in fact in the mid-nineteenth century there was a man named Henry Worrall, who was a teacher at a girls' school in Ohio, who published a piece called "The Spanish Fandango," which was neither Spanish nor a fandango, but anything Spanish was extremely commercial at that point. And that was written in open G tuning. D-G-D-G-B-D. And he had actually published the same piece of music with a different set of variations a few years earlier under the name of "The Celebrated Violet Waltz." And in that he used the normal practice, if you just write it the way it sounds, and you have to figure it out. I mean I've encountered pieces from the 1840s in open E tuning where you just have to do the transpositions. They don't give you any hints. But what he did was Henry Worrall wrote out this piece so that you played it as though it were in standard tuning. You tune the guitar the way he says and then you play it like you read it in standard tuning. But what you hear is different. And so it actually had a little history. That piece has some very — the expression of that was very deep. Because it became, and some people will argue that it's the root of the blues. It's not. But the mechanics of tuning the guitar to an open chord really got established through that. Because that piece ended up in a lot of guitar tutor books, especially, there was a man named Septimus

Winner who published *The Eureka Method*. And if you bought a guitar from Montgomery Ward or Sears, you would get this Eureka Method that would come with it. And so a lot of people learned how to play an open G tuning and you only need one finger to make chords. And you can play primary chords, open string, fifth fret, seventh fret. So yeah, I mean somebody that's heading in the direction of a 12-bar blues will use that. And you can play — one of the things I do in my presentation is play the "Spanish Fandango" and then play the Rolling Stones' "Honky Tonk Woman," which was written in open G tuning. And the melody is almost identical in the chorus.

MR: Wow, it goes around.

LJ: Because it's the mechanics of it. There's a lot of aspects to the guitar that come out of the mechanics rather than out of the pure music. So the challenges of being able to address those kinds of demands made upon the musician by the composer, or even just the technological thing — there was a period where nobody really wanted to stick a microphone in front of an amplifier. And in the 80s everybody was wanting to record direct. And it's like you don't get that.

MR: Yeah. No air is moving.

LJ: Yeah. So you learn how to be accurate. But the ultimate thing I think is having that kind of faith that it will work out. Because it can be kind of scary sometimes. And orchestrators don't always know how to write for guitar. Often you'll see a chord that you know is unplayable, and you're sight reading and it's like okay what's going to work in this context. And I've seen guitar players come across a — because they'll see a G 7 chord in the jazz context, but they won't play the right voicing. They'll play like a cowboy G 7 chord, which will work great in a bluegrass context but doesn't work if you're playing like Freddie Green, you only need three notes. You only need root, seventh and third, and then you're in that realm. So you have to understand the musical context. And this goes back to the beginning of the conversation in terms of the versatility. I try not to draw barriers between musical styles. And it's fascinating — on the plane I watched "Miles Ahead," the Don Cheadle movie that's like the biopic about Miles in that mid-70s period. And the fact that Miles didn't refer to his music as jazz. He referred to it as "social music." And Jimi Hendrix at Woodstock referred to what he was playing as "electric church music," recognizing the spiritual aspect of it. Those labels are very convenient for marketing purposes. You know you go into iTunes and it's like there's a list. When I'm putting my music in it's like how do you describe what I do? Acoustic. I mean I can offer pop, folk, jazz, country. Those are just labels. Music is always music. And it's the marketing of music and it's the placement of music and how it gets tangibly recognized. That's where the labels come. But like I was saying earlier, C

major chord is always a C major chord. It doesn't matter what style. You just have to know how to voice it.

MR: Even tomorrow night in the concert I noticed they didn't really bill you as a blank guitarist, which I thought was good. You're a guitar player and you're choosing your own program, which sort of brings me to my last question. When you get a song started, it's a big hall by the way, and you've got all those people watching you, and you've played the melody, what makes you decide where to go with it?

LJ: It depends where I go with an arrangement or a composition. It may be completely set, completely fixed. Even though there's improvisational arms in there, and even though I may have improvised it in the recording — it's like Nat King Cole for example — didn't improvise in concert. He played what he played on the records because that's what his audiences expected. That's the entertainer side of the equation. Though it may have been improvised in the studio. So there's times — I think tomorrow night I'll probably play "Cry Me a River" for example, an arrangement of that. And that's a fixed arrangement. It was improvised when I recorded it, but I learned, you know I've had it published. The arrangement was published. And Arthur Hamilton wrote it, a friend of mine. And the great thing was before I ever recorded a note of it I played it to Arthur and the joy of being able to play an arrangement to the guy who wrote it, that's pretty special. But where I go, I mean when I play Jimi Hendrix "Little Wing" it was an arrangement that evolved out of improvisations on stage. And for a period I pretty much had it set. And then, especially in more recent years, because I've been getting deeper into improvisation, not just musical improvisation but my wife Hope wrote a play that's set in a theater improv workshop. And working with — I not only produced the play but I also played the shows live, with an acoustic guitar. And actually at the end of the play, even though it's scripted, they do improvisations. And I would collaborate with the actors on the score, and occasionally the guitar would become part of the improvisation. Not bouncing off musicians but bouncing off actors. It really rekindled my enthusiasm for improvisation. And when I'm playing electric guitar, or even acoustic guitar with an ensemble, I can stretch out a lot more. Playing solo the issue really is there's no bass player. So I have to pick up the bass notes too. And that tends to kind of restrict me in certain ways. But like when I'm playing "Little Wing," I just go where the muse takes me. But as an entertainer I also have a responsibility to the audience to stay on the path and let myself — I pick my spots basically. But as time goes on I think more improvisation tends to come into it. But some of my compositions are very fixed, just like they would be if they were quote classical.

MR: Well this has been fascinating for me, you have encyclopedic knowledge. And as I said I admire the versatility.

LJ: Well thanks.

MR: Which — it's very important to make a living in music.

LJ: Well that's exactly it. And because the guitar covers so many different stylistic areas. I mean you play clarinet, sure you can be playing Dixieland or you could be playing Klezmer or playing with an orchestra or doubling on saxophone and doing studio work or whatever. But you're not going to be playing bluegrass for example. And maybe playing like Greek folk music or something, but in certain musical contexts it doesn't fit. But the guitar kind of fits everywhere. And sometimes even when it fits it gets ignored. I did a concert — we have an organization in the L.A. area in Pasadena called Muse/ique. And it's a crossover concert series. And we did a concert a couple of weeks ago at Cal Tech in Pasadena where they have a huge audience, 1300 people, families, and there's an orchestra and a rhythm section. And the orchestra, all the strings are standing up except for the cello. And most of the woodwinds are standing too. And we did a lot of Gershwin. I did my solo arrangement of "Over the Rainbow" and then I did an orchestration of The Beatles "In My Life" where I started solo acoustic, brought in a small woodwind section and then bring in the strings and then I switch over to electric guitar and then the rhythm section kicks in. You know so it made it kind of a performance piece. But there were tunes that we were doing which just the guitar would have been perfect for. But the guitar doesn't get orchestrated for. You know, like the Pasadena Pops for example, I don't play with them, Paul Viapiano is a local guy who specializes in classical. They do Vivaldi's "Four Seasons." They don't use a harpsichord for the continuo, they use a guitar. It's like that was always the case in the early Baroque, was that you had your lutes and theorbos, and you had a big rhythm section. It wasn't just the harpsichord. It kind of became distilled down to that we think. But then you start to look at performance practice and you realize, wait a minute.

MR: So Freddie Green was doing his thing back then.

LJ: Yeah, in Renaissance Italy when Monteverdi did "Orfeo" he had his Freddie Green you know, Federico Verdi.

MR: Well I wish you the best in your future projects, and at the same time I hope those residual checks keep coming.

LJ: Well let's hope so. I get my pension next year.

MR: Thanks so much for your time. I appreciate it.